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By Gabriel Gavin, Gerardo Fortuna · Sep 9, 2026, 6:45 PM · [View in your browser](#)

BRUSSELS — The EU's plans for a deeper partnership with Canada, aimed at helping the country withstand a trade war with the U.S., has won the support of governments across the political spectrum — including those usually cautious about angering Donald Trump's administration.

Ambassadors representing the bloc's 27 governments met in Brussels on Wednesday to discuss the move, just hours after the White House banned Canadian exports of dairy, alcohol and motorbikes in an escalating tariff feud.

The EU's idea would see ties strengthened in areas like technology, trade and critical raw materials, according to two people in the meeting who were granted anonymity by POLITICO because the talks were confidential. Despite the risk of the EU being seen to side against Washington, no capital raised objections, they said.

The European Commission and the European Council jointly presented preparations for a landmark summit with Canada on Oct. 29-30, committing to explore new areas where they will step up their partnership. That includes sectors like technology, research and innovation, as well as mining for valuable rare metals and breaking down trade barriers, those involved said.

"There's very strong support for [Commission President] von der Leyen making that outreach and for closer cooperation," said a third diplomat with knowledge of the preparations. That's despite a handful of countries, including Giorgia Meloni's Italy, Andrej Babiš's Czech Republic and Robert Fico's Slovakia, traditionally seeking close ties with the Trump camp and trying to avoid outright provocations.

Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney will address the European Parliament next week on a trip first reported by POLITICO, as part of a public campaign to pivot away from dependency on the U.S. and form a club of like-minded, pro-free trade democracies. The visit is designed "to clearly signal the intention and ambition on both sides to upgrade our partnership," a senior EU official said.

From the Arctic to the universities

Carney's trip, which coincides with von der Leyen's State of the Union speech, has sparked a search for concrete ideas on areas for closer collaboration. Participation in the EU's Erasmus student exchange scheme, alignment on security and defense in the Arctic region and military-industrial partnerships are among those areas being considered, according to nine EU officials and one diplomat familiar with the discussions.

No broad new partnership has been agreed, however, and officials cautioned that talks remain at an early stage. For now, the aim is to demonstrate political ambition and identify areas where the two sides can deepen cooperation, with Carney expected to set out more practical next steps in his speech.

The Commission is preparing an updated Arctic policy, currently expected on Oct. 20 and renamed the North Neighbourhood and Arctic Strategy to reflect its broader geographic focus. Von der Leyen, meanwhile, recently returned from Greenland saying Europe wanted to become “more engaged in the Arctic.”

That makes the region a potentially useful bridge between Brussels’ strategic priorities and Ottawa’s.

Another EU official said any reference to Canada in the speech could center on security, potentially through some form of Arctic security initiative. “Security and defense is always her happy place,” the official said when asked what form an overture to Carney might take.

Cooperation in the region could extend well beyond defense. A third official who has worked on the Arctic strategy pointed to existing and potential cooperation on critical raw materials, subsea cables and specialized equipment needed to operate in the High North, including icebreakers and other Arctic-capable vessels. Cleaner shipping is another area where the two sides’ interests overlap — and diverge from the U.S., which has lobbied against decarbonization in the industry .

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